1. Build a private writing and editing assistant

Writing is a good first workload because it needs no special model architecture and lets you learn how much difference a clear instruction makes.

Do not begin with "write something about electric cars". Start with a real task and constraints.

For example:

"Rewrite the following paragraph for a general technology audience. Preserve every factual claim and number. Cut repetition. Do not introduce new facts. Keep the result between 120 and 140 words."

Paste the paragraph below the instruction.

A small instruction-tuned model can often handle this well, and because the material remains local when you use a genuinely local runtime, drafts that you are not comfortable uploading elsewhere can stay on your computer. LM Studio states that prompts entered while chatting with downloaded local models do not leave the device.



Step-by-step: create a reusable writing workflow

- **Step 1: Choose your fast model.** Use the smaller general-purpose model from your three-model shortlist rather than reaching immediately for the biggest one.
- **Step 2: Set a system instruction.** Try: "You are an editor. Preserve facts, numbers, names and quotes. Never invent supporting information."
- **Step 3: Separate instruction from source material.** Clearly label sections such as `TASK:` and `SOURCE:`. This reduces ambiguity when the pasted text itself contains commands or questions.
- **Step 4: Ask for one transformation at a time.** Rewrite first. Shorten afterward. Asking for five stylistic operations simultaneously makes it harder to identify where the model went wrong.
- **Step 5: Compare against the source.** Check numbers, names, quotations and whether the model silently removed a qualification such as "approximately" or "up to".

LOCAL DOESN'T MEAN CONFIDENTIAL

Running inference on your machine removes one important data-transfer step, but privacy still depends on the rest of your setup. A local application can have update checks, plugins, MCP servers, telemetry options or folders synchronised to cloud storage. Malware on the computer can also read local files.

Treat "local" as an architecture choice, not a security guarantee. For sensitive material, confirm that the exact model is running locally, disable unnecessary integrations, know where chat histories are stored and check whether the source folder itself is backed up to a cloud service. If the requirement is stronger than ordinary privacy – legal, regulated or highly confidential work – follow the organisation's security policy rather than assuming an offline LLM is automatically approved.

Once you find a prompt that reliably works, save it. Your local AI becomes more useful when you stop rediscovering instructions every session.

Good writing tasks include summarising notes, changing tone, generating headline variations, extracting action items, restructuring rough notes and converting prose into bullet points.

A poor task is asking the model to add current supporting statistics while offline. It cannot retrieve facts it does not possess merely because the prompt sounds confident.

2. Ask questions of your own documents

Document work is where local AI starts feeling substantially different from a normal chatbot.

LM Studio allows `.pdf`, `.docx` and `.txt` documents to be attached to a chat. If a document is short enough to fit inside the model's context, its contents can be supplied directly. If it

